CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: NZ election deadlocked, official count due Nov 27 · Victoria Barracks sale scrapped · Walmart backs Australian lamb before Trump-Albanese meeting · One in five trust Albanese · Fiji PM denies stalling constitution bill

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,021	0.6868	13,998	0.5548
+1.27%	-2.29%	+1.46%	-1.37%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. New Zealand heads into weeks of coalition bargaining after National's projected 42 seats and Labour's 36 were separated by just 3,650 party votes, with the Electoral Commission's official count due November 27.
2. Canberra scrapped the sale of Victoria Barracks and three other heritage defence sites after a cross-party backlash that drew in John Howard and the RSL, abandoning part of a plan to raise up to $1.8 billion from the Defence estate.
3. Walmart's public backing of Australian lamb producers lands days before a Trump-Albanese meeting in the Philippines at which sheep meat tariffs are expected to be raised.

TOP STORIES

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand election leaves National and Labour locked in a historic deadlock

New Zealand's election produced one of the tightest results in MMP history: National is projected on 42 seats to Labour's 36, the two parties separated by *3,650 party votes*, 710,330 for Labour against 706,680 for National. **Christopher Luxon** told supporters at Auckland's Viaduct Events Centre the result was "too close to call" but that National had "a pathway to forming the next government". Roughly 300,000 to 399,000 special votes remain uncounted, with official results due November 27.

per ABC News (Stephen Dziedzic): "NZ election figures tell story of disenchantment and fracturing" · also RNZ Pacific (wire)

AU-DEFENSE

Albanese scraps Victoria Barracks sale after cross-party backlash

Anthony Albanese has abandoned the sale of Sydney's 166-year-old Victoria Barracks, along with Victoria Barracks Melbourne, Fort Queenscliff and Point Cook (RAAF Williams), transferring the four heritage-listed sites from Defence to the Finance Department. They were among 67 Defence properties marked for sale after an independent estate audit in February, intended to raise *$1.8 billion*. **Richard Marles** denied the decision would undermine Australia's defence. The Coalition, Greens, One Nation, teal independents, RSL Australia and former prime minister **John Howard** had all condemned the sale.

per Guardian (Sarah Basford Canales): "Victoria Barracks in Sydney and Melbourne to remain in public hands after partial backtrack on defence property selloff" · also ABC News

US-AUSTRALIA

Walmart backs Australian lamb as tariff fight looms over Trump-Albanese meeting

Walmart has sided with Australian producers in a dispute over sheep meat imports, days before **Anthony Albanese** meets **Donald Trump** in the Philippines. The AFR reports the threat of further US tariffs on Australian sheep meat is likely to be on the table at that meeting. The intervention by the largest US grocery retailer gives Canberra a domestic American ally as it argues against new duties on agricultural exports.

per AFR: "Walmart backs Australia in lamb stoush ahead of Trump-Albanese meeting"

OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

Only one in five voters trust Albanese as cost-of-living blame sticks · SMH Federal Politics

Voters are squarely blaming the Labor government and its most recent budget for the cost-of-living crisis, with *42 percent* singling out the government as responsible, the Herald reports. Trust in **Anthony Albanese** has fallen to around one in five voters.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Climate finance and just transition to dominate COP31 agenda · PNG Post-Courier

Climate finance, adaptation and the transition away from fossil fuels will dominate negotiations at COP31 in Türkiye, Post-Courier reports, with developing countries demanding greater access to funding and technology to confront worsening climate impacts. Pacific delegations have been pressing the finance question through the Commonwealth and the Forum.

CHINA-PACIFIC

Fiji rules out sending soldiers to the Taiwan Strait · Fiji Sun

Fiji's **Pio Tikoduadua** said no Fijian soldiers would be deployed to the Taiwan Strait, Fiji Sun reports. Fiji is not among the three Pacific Islands Forum members, the Marshall Islands, Palau and Tuvalu, that hold formal diplomatic relations with Taiwan.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Two Australians survive waterbombing helicopter crash in Indonesia · ABC News

Two Australian crew members survived after an Australian-registered waterbombing helicopter nosedived into a river in Indonesia's South Kalimantan province; a third Indonesian crew member is missing. Indonesia's National Disaster Mitigation Agency said the aircraft was contracted by Indonesian authorities during the country's worst forest and land fire season in more than a decade.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Weather Ready Pacific lifts tsunami warning capacity across the region · PNG Post-Courier

Pacific National Meteorological Services are strengthening their ability to warn communities of tsunami threats under the Weather Ready Pacific program, Post-Courier reports. The work follows a regional early-warning meeting held in Rarotonga earlier this month.

STAT OF THE DAY

3,650

party votes separating Labour and National in New Zealand

Labour polled 710,330 party votes to National's 706,680 on preliminary counting, with about 399,000 special votes still to be counted before the November 27 declaration.

ABC News

PACIFIC WIRE

MICRONESIA (FSM) · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Micronesian veterans still waiting on health care Congress authorised in 2024

The Compact of Free Association Amendments Act of 2024 gave the US Department of Veterans Affairs discretionary authority to provide hospital care and medical services to eligible veterans in the freely associated states. A September 25 Government Accountability Office report found the VA is pursuing only partial implementation and has set no timeline. Chuukese veteran **Domingko Saladier**, living in Guam, said the absence of a schedule "has got to be frustrating".

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Aitutaki front-runner for the Cook Islands Party's seventh ministry

Aitutaki has emerged as the front-runner for the Cook Islands Party's seventh ministerial position, Cook Islands News reports, as opposition forces court MPs in an attempt to block the incumbent government from securing a fifth consecutive term.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

NGO presses Rarotonga to spell out risks in seabed minerals merger

Te Ipukarea Society is calling on the Cook Islands government and the Seabed Minerals Authority to explain the risks and complexities of the proposed merger between American Ocean Minerals Corporation and Odyssey Marine Exploration before approving any related arrangements.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Rabuka denies extending constitution consultations to save his position

Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** rejected Unity Fiji leader **Savenaca Narube**'s claim that extending consultations on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 is designed to buy time to secure coalition votes. "Not correct. I want to give the people more time to be heard," Rabuka said, adding he would accept the decisions of coalition partners.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji's Parliament tightens election funding and disclosure rules

Fiji's Parliament has passed changes tightening election funding and disclosure requirements, Fiji Sun reports. The measure moves alongside the Police Bill and the Constitution (Amendment) Bill in a dense legislative run

ahead of the next general election.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Marape flags new family planning policy for PNG

Prime Minister **James Marape** said the government plans to introduce a new family planning policy aimed at addressing Papua New Guinea's growing demographic and healthcare pressures, Post-Courier reports.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG and FAO launch $9.8 million health and conservation projects

The Papua New Guinea government and the Food and Agriculture Organization launched two initiatives worth *US$9.8 million*, reported locally as K44 million, on November 6, aimed at strengthening national resilience and sustainable development.

COOK ISLANDS · ABC PACIFIC

Rarotonga revives ancient terrace farming to protect its reef

Scientists and cultural guardians are reviving an ancient terrace system in Rarotonga's Takuva'ine Valley to curb land-based pollution feeding an outbreak of taramea, crown-of-thorns starfish, threatening the reef. The ABC reporting was produced with Australian government funds supporting Pacific climate coverage ahead of COP31.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Turnout tracks to the second lowest in New Zealand history

The Electoral Commission said *74.6 percent* of eligible voters cast a ballot, 2,831,768 people, down from 78.2 percent in 2023. Advance votes made up 67.3 percent of the total, against 61.4 percent three years ago. An estimated 399,365 special votes remain, 96,947 of them from overseas. Chief Electoral Officer **Karl Le Quesne** said official results are due Friday, November 27.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Luxon denies snubbing Chris Bishop after minister loses Hutt South

Chris Bishop finished 889 votes behind Labour's **Ginny Anderson** in Hutt South, and his third ranking on National's list was not enough to keep him in Parliament. Bishop held transport, housing, infrastructure, Resource Management Act reform, and sport and recreation last term. **Christopher Luxon** said his omission from the election-night speech was not a snub, as Bishop had not yet conceded.

NZ-POLITICS · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Minor parties take the gains as New Zealand's majors hit historic lows

Preliminary results put the combined National-Labour vote share at around *60 percent*, historically low for the two majors. The Greens took 16 seats, ACT 13, New Zealand First 12, the new centrist party Opportunity 7, and Te Pati Maori 5. The Pacific Island Times notes a left-of-centre government might be more inclined to engage a Democratic-controlled US Congress than the Trump administration.

NZ-DEFENSE · NZDF

NZDF rededicates Passchendaele soldier's grave in Belgium

Sergeant Thomas Smith, who died at the Battle of Passchendaele on October 12, 1917, was rededicated with a named headstone at Tyne Cot Cemetery on November 6, after research by volunteers, the Commonwealth War Graves Commission and NZDF historians. Captain **James Barnes**, New Zealand Defence Attache to Belgium, organised the ceremony.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Canavan backs staying in Paris but rejects the EU trade deal

Nationals leader **Matt Canavan** told ABC's Insiders Australia should remain in the Paris Agreement while rejecting the EU free trade agreement, which he says would legally bind Australia to Paris commitments beyond its current obligations. "What we can't afford is a mad pursuit of net zero," he said, adding he had texted Trade Minister **Don Farrell** seeking a constructive discussion.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Paterson calls the barracks backdown a humiliation for Marles

Shadow Defence Minister **James Paterson** described the reversal on Victoria Barracks as a "humiliation" for **Richard Marles**. RSL Australia and the opposition welcomed the backdown while calling it only a partial victory, with the remainder of the 67 sites identified in February's estate audit still slated for disposal.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Payman embraces an 'aggressive' turn less than two years from her first test

Senator **Fatima Payman**, who quit Labor to sit as an independent, is adopting what the Herald describes as a new "aggressive" energy less than two years out from her first electoral test as an independent. Her Senate vote remains in play for the government's legislative program.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Data centres loom as an electoral liability in Australia

Data centres became a cost-of-living and local-community issue in the US midterms, reshaping gubernatorial races in Texas, Georgia and Ohio, with ballot measures restricting them approved across California, Illinois, Maine and New York. Texas accounted for *25 percent* of planned US data centre capacity. The ABC reports Australian voters are not yet convinced the infrastructure is worth its cost.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Gerry Harvey lifts stake in PNG cement venture as US DFC circles

Harvey Norman chairman **Gerry Harvey** has topped up his stake in Pacific Lime and Cement, a Papua New Guinea-focused producer. The AFR reports the US government's Development Finance Corporation could soon join the shareholder register, which would put American state capital alongside Australian private money in PNG construction materials.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Australian home sales rise in a tentative sign of property recovery

Bloomberg reports home sales rose in what it calls a fledgling sign of recovery in the Australian property market, a counterpoint to the housing slump reported last week as the Reserve Bank lifted rates.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Yellow Tail owner sees 'no end in sight' to the wine downturn

Casella Family Brands, owner of the Yellow Tail label and one of Australia's largest wine exporters, warned there is "no end in sight" to the industry's downturn, The Australian reports.

UPCOMING

NOV 27

New Zealand Electoral Commission declares official 2026 election results

Roughly 399,000 special votes will settle whether National or Labour can assemble a governing majority, and with it New Zealand's foreign and defence posture.

NOV 2026

Albanese meets Trump in the Philippines

Australian sheep meat tariffs are expected on the agenda, with Walmart having publicly backed Australian producers.

NOV 2026

Fiji's extended consultations on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026

Rabuka needs coalition numbers to pass the bill, and the extension has already drawn accusations of political manoeuvring.

NOV 2026

COP31 negotiations in Turkiye

Climate finance and adaptation funding are the Pacific's central asks, and Pacific delegations are pressing for access to funding and technology.

MAY 2027

Australian federal budget

The $1.8 billion expected from Defence estate sales is now partly unwound, leaving a revenue gap to be addressed.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ABC PACIFIC

Israel's Forum partnership tests the Pacific's decolonisation record

The Pacific Islands Forum's decision to admit Israel as a sectoral partner came days after Israel and the United States opposed UN decolonisation resolutions affecting six Pacific territories still listed as non-self-governing. Samoa's Prime Minister **Laaulialemalietoa Polataivao Fosi Schmidt** backed Israel on being sworn in.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islanders voted in New Zealand's election from Avarua

Thomas Tarurongo Wynne writes that Cook Islanders holding New Zealand passports voted at the High Commission in Avarua or uploaded ballots from home, and weighs what each of the two possible Wellington governments would mean for Rarotonga.

US-AUSTRALIA

ABC POLITICS

ABC reads the midterms as a check on Trump, not the end of MAGA

Exit polls showed voters angry about fuel, food and fertiliser prices driven by the trade war, with alleged government corruption ranking above cost of living in some surveys. The ABC analysis cautions that the Democratic result does not guarantee a lasting realignment.

NZ-POLITICS

RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Greens' Tamatha Paul leads Wellington North as Opportunity takes 15 percent

Labour took 30.4 percent of the party vote in Wellington North to the Greens' 27.1 percent and National's 18.0 percent, with the new Opportunity party on *15.1 percent*. **Tamatha Paul** leads the electorate contest.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

MAX BLENKIN · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Calling for a stronger Navy

Retired Rear Admiral Rowan Moffit told the Australian Naval Institute's Goldrick Seminar that some Navy capabilities are on life support and others in palliative care, with much of the shrinking surface combatant fleet older and relatively less capable than the ships of the World War II Scrap Iron Flotilla. He said submarines will serve past retirement age. By 2045, he argued, current plans would return the surface fleet to roughly the firepower it held late last century while regional navies advance well beyond that.

Argument: Defence bureaucracy has hollowed out Australian naval capability and the current build plan will not restore it in time.

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Submarines sail troubled waters

Australian Defence Magazine examines difficulties facing the submarine programme. The piece is behind a paywall and only the headline summary is available.

Argument: Australia's submarine programme faces compounding schedule and capability pressures.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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